

The Hansard

A WEEKLY DIGEST OF THE PROCEEDINGS OF THE PARLIAMENT OF THE UNITED KINGDOM

Belfast: a near-fatal knife attack, and the question it forced on the Commons

A man in his forties is fighting life-threatening injuries in a Belfast hospital after a knife was held to his throat in the street on Monday night — an attack three passers-by ran in to stop. Within a day it

had become a political emergency: serious disorder across the city, a flood of claims true and false, and an Urgent Question that put the Northern Ireland Secretary on the spot over immigration and the border

— close to the only part of this Westminster can answer for. It was the gravest story of the week; it was also a week in which MPs voted eight times, six of them on steel.

THE DIVISIONS, CLOSEST FIRST

Steel Industry (Nationalisation) Bill, New Clause...		145–251
Steel Industry (Nationalisation) Bill, New Clause...		157–287
Agriculture (Delinked Payments)...		302–155
Steel Industry (Nationalisation) Bill, Amendment 12		81–266
Steel Industry (Nationalisation) Bill, New Clause 2		65–251
Steel Industry (Nationalisation) Bill, Amendment 20		90–290
Steel Industry (Nationalisation) Bill, New Clause...		94–297
Combined Authorities (Mayoral Electio...		356–86

WRITTEN QUESTIONS, BY DEPARTMENT

Health	320
Transport	218
Home Office	172
Environment	159
Housing	158
Defence	155
Treasury	130
Business and Trade	125
18 others	724

THE MOST-ASKED SUBJECTS

10 HM Coastguard: Conditions of Employment · 10 Lord Mandelson · 8 Prostate Cancer: Screening · 7 Electric Vehicles: Charging Points · 7 Police: Equality · 7 Construction: Training · 6 Members: Correspondence · 5 Agriculture: UK Trade with EU · 5 Tyres: Waste Disposal · 5 Youth Diversion Orders

THE FEATURE

The Urgent Question, and the answer the Secretary of State couldn't give

With policing and justice devolved to Stormont and the PSNI, Westminster's hold on the Belfast attack is narrow — which is why the Commons' set-piece on it, an Urgent Question from the DUP's Gavin Robinson, turned on the reserved questions of immigration, asylum and the border rather than the investigation itself (charged as attempted murder; the victim, a man in his forties, is fighting

life-threatening injuries and has not been named). Robinson pressed on the suspect's reported five-year visa and on community cohesion; Carla Lockhart on the land border with the Republic. These are legitimate questions, and the House pressed them — but the one that mattered most, whether the man charged had entered the UK legally, drew only that Hilary Benn could not confirm it.

A SAMPLE OF THE WEEK'S QUESTIONS

Immigration · Mike Martin, Liberal Democrat

When does the Department plan to respond to the Earned Settlement consultation that closed on 12 February 2026?

THE ANSWER The earned settlement model, proposed in 'A Fairer Pathway to Settlement', was subject to a public consultation which opened on 20 November 2025 and closed on 12 February 2026. We received over 200,000 responses and are now in the process of carefully considering the feedback received.

THE RECORD

Every figure checked against the official Parliament record. Compiled from the Official Report, the written question record and the division lists, and rendered to one sheet for the week.